

Reading Rhetorically

Module Web Site 1 – *Apply Magic Sauce*

Preparing to Read

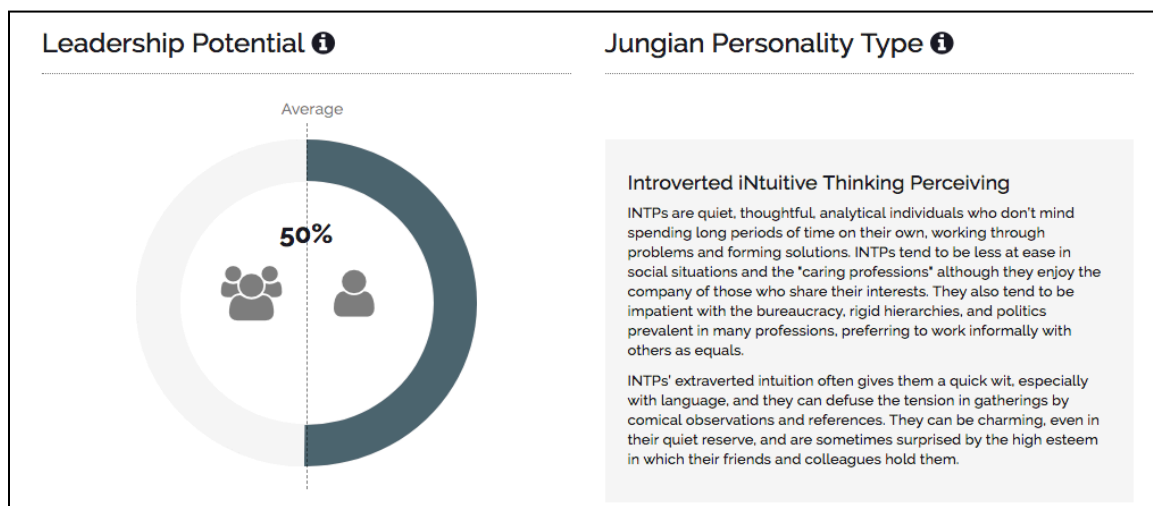
Activity 1: Getting Ready to Read – Magic Sauce Web Site

In March of 2017, a company called Cambridge Analytica, which analyzed data to help political campaigns, claimed it could predict the personality and politics of every American adult simply by gathering information from their online behavior.

The University of Cambridge Psychometric Centre, a research group whose stated purpose is to help personalize people's experience on the Internet, has also developed computer algorithms that use data collected online to make the same kind of "psychographic" profiles of individuals. In 2017, these were their research results: "Given enough data, the algorithm was better able to predict a person's personality traits than any of the human participants. It needed access to just 10 likes to beat a work colleague, 70 to beat a roommate, 150 to beat a parent or sibling, and 300 to beat a spouse." *

Apply Magic Sauce is an interactive Web site posted by The Psychometric Centre (applymagicsauce.com). If you gave it access to your Twitter and/or Facebook accounts, it would develop several profiles of you, including personality profiles, based on things you have "liked" or online posts you have written. Below are screenshots of an Apply Magic Sauce profile for a real-life adult. The demographic predictions (age and gender) are off, but the personality predictions are remarkably accurate.

Task: First, skim through the sample Magic Sauce results. Then, in a two-part quickwrite, respond to one question from Set A and one question from Set B. Discuss the questions as a class.



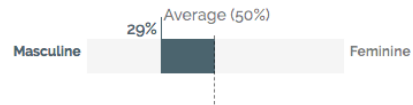
The following prediction is based on **62** Facebook posts, from which **9243** bytes of text were used

Age

33

Your digital footprint suggests that your online behaviour resembles that of a 30-39 years old

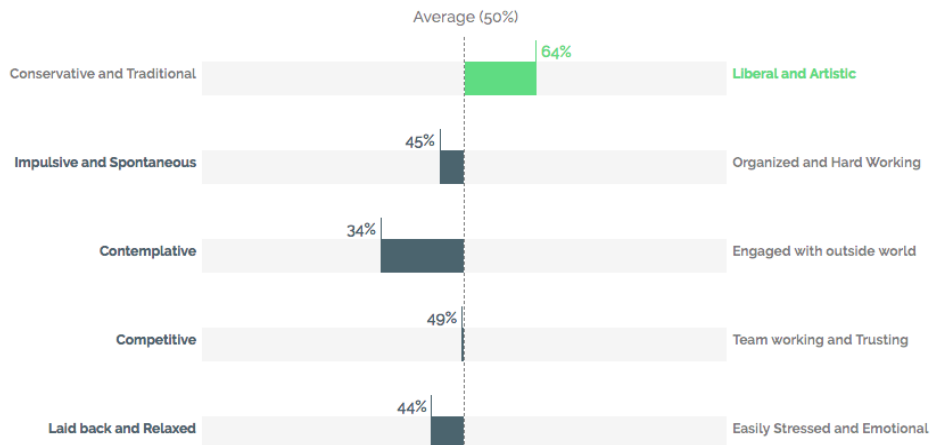
Psychological Gender



Your digital footprint suggests that you are Male

Big 5 Personality (Predictions are expressed as percentiles)

[Take personality test](#)



Respond to one question from Set A and one question from Set B.

Set A

- Who might be various audiences for the Apply Magic Sauce Web site? What types of audiences might benefit from knowing what an adult values or fears? What types of audiences might benefit from knowing this technology exists?

Openness to experience describes a dimension of personality that distinguishes imaginative, creative people from down-to-earth, conventional people.

Your digital footprint suggests that you are intellectually curious and appreciative of what you consider beautiful, no matter what others think. You might say that your imagination is vivid and makes you more creative than many others.

Conscientiousness concerns the way in which we control, regulate, and direct our impulses.

Your digital footprint suggests that you are random and fun to be around but can also plan and persist when life requires it. It appears that depending on the situation, you can make quick decisions or deliberate for longer if necessary.

Extraversion is marked by pronounced engagement with the external world, versus being comfortable with your own company.

Your digital footprint suggests that you are similar to people who prefer low-key social occasions, with a few close friends. You might say that it's not that you are afraid of large parties; they're just not that fun for you.

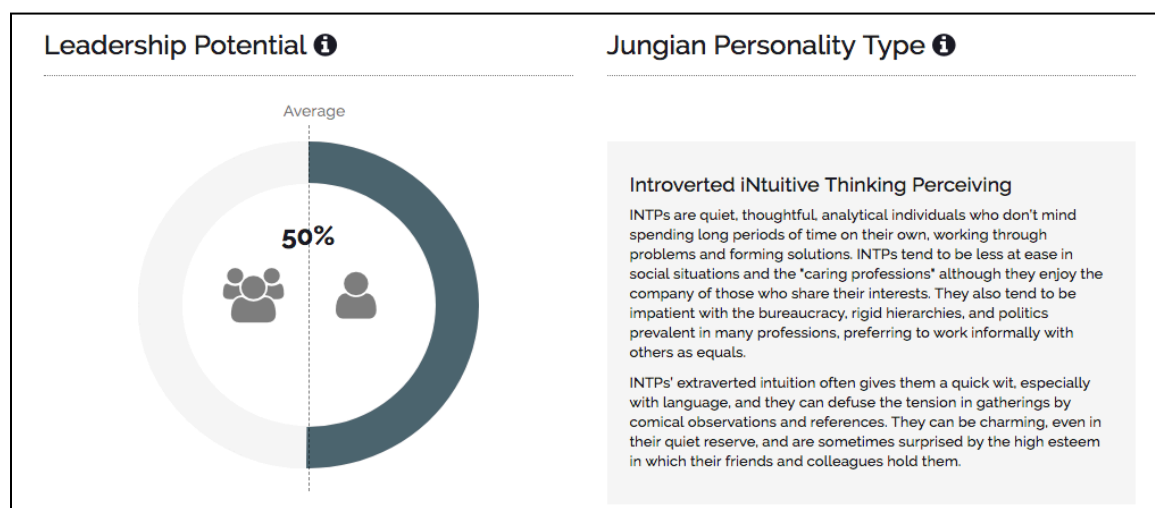
Agreeableness reflects individual differences in concern with cooperation and social harmony.

Your digital footprint suggests that you get along well with others, especially once they have proved themselves to be trustworthy. You seem to have a healthy scepticism about others' motives, but that doesn't stop you from considering others to be basically honest and decent.

Neuroticism refers to the tendency to experience negative emotions.

Your digital footprint suggests that you are generally calm. You come across as someone who can feel emotional or stressed out by some experiences, but your feelings tend to be warranted by the situation.

- What did you notice about the sample psychographic results? Did anything surprise you?



Set B

- Which do you imagine gives someone more persuasive leverage: basic demographic data (the means to target a group based on skin color, age, and income) or psychological data (the means to target an individual based on their values, fears, and group associations)? Why do you say so?
- In January 2017, Vice News reported that Cambridge researchers were studying the effectiveness of their personality profiles. Their early findings suggested that using personality rather than demography to target audiences, Facebook posts could attract up to 63 percent more clicks.** When people are using social media platforms, what can entice them to click a new link? How might knowing somebody's temperament, values, or politics help online authors to write a tempting clickbait title?

Set C (optional)

- Some social media companies are experimenting with removing “likes” from social media posts. What are the benefits and drawbacks of allowing users to interact with posts in this way? Should “likes” be removed from all platforms?

How else—besides tracking “likes”—do companies collect data about their users? Would removing like buttons disrupt company's ability to gather psychographic data about users? How else can media providers infer what users like?